

Pakistan Studies 2nd Semester

Establishment of Muslim societies on the Subcontinent

Muhammad ibn al-Qasim: was an Arab military commander in service of the Umayyad Caliphate who led the Muslim conquest of Sindh (and Punjab, part of ancient Sindh), inaugurating the Umayyad campaigns in India

Muhammad bin Qasim started the conquest of Sindh in 711 AD, with the major victories occurring in 712 AD and continuing until 715 AD, when he was recalled. He led the Umayyad Caliphate's forces to defeat Raja Dahir, the ruler of Sindh, establishing Muslim rule over the region. It is for this reason that Sindh is referred to as Bab-ul-Islam, the gateway of Islam.

The attack on Sindh took place primarily due to pirates raiding a ship carrying gifts from the King of Serendib (Sri Lanka) to the Umayyad Caliph, resulting in the enslavement of the passengers, which included Muslim Women. When the Caliph Al-Hajjah ibn Yusuf asked the Raja Dahir to hand over the prisoners, Dahir refused to do so, claiming that the pirates were not his responsibility because he had no control over the pirates in the Indian Ocean. This led to the Caliph sending Muhammad Bin Qasim to Sindh.

The campaign was also motivated by the Arab desire to establish a strong base in the region for economic and strategic reasons, protect maritime interests, and cut off a refuge for rebel chieftains.

Regime of Muhammad Bin Qasim

1. When Qasim conquered Sindh in 712, the local people breathed a sigh of relief.
2. Everyone was given full religious freedom.
3. All taxes were abolished and jазiah* was imposed.
4. Sindh was made the gateway of Islam.
5. Muslims learned Science and Technology, Chemistry, Physics, Geography and Agriculture.
6. Qasim constructed many mosques and madrasas where scholars shared their knowledge.
7. Sea pirates were crushed and sea trade flourished.
8. The port of Debul* was made a very busy and very prosperous commercial centre.

*Jазiah: Jaziya was a per-capita tax historically levied on non-Muslim male subjects in some states governed by Islamic law. In exchange for paying the tax, these individuals, known as dhimmi or "protected people," were granted protection of their lives and property, and were

exempt from military service, which was a requirement for Muslims. Women, children, the elderly, the sick, and the poor were generally exempt from paying jiziya.

*Debul: Debul was an ancient port city in Sindh, Pakistan, located near modern-day Karachi. It was a significant commercial town and the site of the first conquest in the Indian subcontinent by the Umayyad forces under Muhammad bin Qasim in 712 AD.

Q) Did the Arabs arrive in the subcontinent as traders?

The Arab traders, who were the followers of the Holy Prophet, came to the coastal areas of Sindh, bearing clothes, spices, etc. The area was called Debul, Thatta. Sindh at the time was ruled by Raja Dahil of the brahmin caste.

Comparative Analysis between Muslims and Hindus

1) Religious Differences

- Muslims are Monotheists, while Hindus are polytheists.
- Muslims believe in the finality of the Holy Prophet.
- Muslims believe in the hereafter, whereas Hindu's believe in reincarnation.
- Muslims believe in equality.

2) Social and Cultural differences

- Gender is of great importance in Islam. The daughter of the Holy Prophet was highly respected. Whereas Hindu society had practiced sati rituals in the past, where widows immolated* themselves on their husbands funeral pyres.
- Infanticide is considered a grave sin in Islam as decreed in the Quran, whereas infanticide was practiced by some groups among the Hindu people.
- No concept of dowry exists in Islamic society.

*immolated: kill or offer as a sacrifice, especially by burning.

3) Political differences

- Muslims established a central bureaucracy* with organized departments, whereas Hindus ruled through regional monarchies where the power was split between Rulers and Nobles.
- Muslim rulers gained legitimacy through Shariah Law and services to Allah, whereas Hindu rulers claimed divine or hereditary authority based on caste and religion.
- Muslims followed codified Islamic laws ensuring administrative uniformity, whereas Hindus based Justice on caste rules and customs, leading to varied local systems..

*bureaucracy: a system of organization and administration characterized by a strict hierarchy, a division of labor, formal rules, and a chain of command

4) Conceptual Differences

- The concept of daily life in Islam is for the preservation of Allah, whereas In Hindu society, daily life is spent for self preservation.
- Muslim rulers viewed authority as a trust from Allah, making the ruler accountable for justice and welfare, whereas Hindu rulers saw kingship as a divine right, where the king upheld dharma* and social order through religious sanction.

*Dharma: (in Indian religion) the eternal and inherent nature of reality, regarded in Hinduism as a cosmic law underlying right behaviour and social order.